

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

## Grant Writing Masterclass

### Module 11 — Building a Grant Program That Lasts

*Student Course Companion — Final Module*

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Organization: \_\_\_\_\_

Team / Cohort (if applicable): \_\_\_\_\_

This workbook is your companion to Module 11 — the final session of the Grant Writing Masterclass. We shift from individual proposals to long-term strategy: how to generate sustained foundation revenue, keep your proposals fresh, and build the professional habits that separate organizations that get funded consistently from those that don't. Team prompts appear in green throughout.

### Section 1 — Key Terms & Concepts

These are the core concepts for Module 11 — the language of a sustainable, professional grant development program.

|                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Grant Campaign</b>     | A coordinated, ongoing strategy for generating foundation revenue built on three activities: research, relationship-building, and proposal submission. Distinguished from a series of standalone transactions by its intentionality and long-term arc. |
| <b>Prospect Research</b>  | The discipline of identifying, evaluating, and continuously updating a list of funders whose priorities, geography, grant size, and funding cycle align with your organization's programs and needs. Not a one-time task — an ongoing discipline.      |
| <b>Funder Cultivation</b> | The process of building genuine relationships with program officers before, between, and after grant submissions. Includes attending briefings, sending updates, requesting pre-application conversations, and following up after decisions.           |
| <b>Cold Submission</b>    | A grant proposal submitted to a funder with whom no prior relationship has been established. Performs significantly worse                                                                                                                              |

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

|                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                | than a tailored submission backed by research and relationship-building.                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>12–18 Month Pipeline</b>    | The realistic timeline from beginning to cultivate a new funder to receiving a first grant check. Not a timeline for organizations in a cash crisis — a long-term revenue strategy that creates compounding returns once established.                                             |
| <b>Boilerplate</b>             | The reusable sections of a grant proposal drafted once and carried forward across submissions: organizational history, mission statement, population description, program model. Must be refreshed every grant cycle.                                                             |
| <b>Paper Clip Stories</b>      | The current research, news items, community data, and case studies circulating in your field right now. Reading them keeps your Needs Statement grounded in the most current available evidence. Replacing outdated statistics with current ones is a minimum annual requirement. |
| <b>Notification Timeline</b>   | The period between grant submission and funder decision — typically three to six months. Must be factored into program planning so grant funds are not needed before they can realistically arrive.                                                                               |
| <b>Signature Logistics</b>     | The process of obtaining required authorized signatures on a proposal before submission. Must be planned in advance. A complete proposal that cannot be submitted because a signatory is unavailable is a preventable failure.                                                    |
| <b>10% Benchmark (Ask)</b>     | A guideline for sizing grant requests with new or young funder relationships: keep your ask at or below 10% of your total program budget to signal diversification and reduce the funder's perceived risk.                                                                        |
| <b>Relationship Growth Arc</b> | The intentional process of growing grant asks over successive funding cycles as a funder relationship matures. A foundation that gave \$10,000 in year one can become a \$60,000 partner by year five — if every cycle demonstrates responsible stewardship.                      |
| <b>Grant Readiness</b>         | The organizational state of having current, complete, and organized proposal components — narrative, attachments, data, and relationships — ready to assemble for any submission at any time. Built through disciplined year-round maintenance.                                   |

## Section 2 — Annotated Example

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

Read the annotated examples below. The right column explains what each approach demonstrates about the organization's grant development maturity. As you read, assess where your own organization currently sits.

## Sample: Grant Campaign in Action vs. Transactional Grant Writing

| SCENARIO                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | WHAT IT DEMONSTRATES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>[GRANT CAMPAIGN APPROACH]</b></p> <p><i>In January, the development director attends a Hartwell Foundation funder briefing and introduces herself to the program officer. In March, she sends a two-paragraph program update — no ask, just results. In June, she requests a pre-application conversation to confirm alignment before the October deadline. In August, she submits a tailored proposal citing the funder's 2025 priority language directly. In December, she receives a \$45,000 award. In January of the following year, she sends a thank-you with a one-page outcome summary. By year three, the ask has grown to \$80,000.</i></p> | <p>→ 12+ months of cultivation before submission</p> <p>→ Update sent without an ask — builds trust, not transactions</p> <p>→ Pre-application conversation confirms alignment before writing begins</p> <p>→ Post-award thank-you with outcomes strengthens the next cycle</p> <p>→ Ask grows from \$45K to \$80K over three years through demonstrated stewardship</p> |
| <p><b>[TRANSACTIONAL APPROACH — CONTRAST]</b></p> <p><i>In September, the executive director finds a foundation deadline on a grant calendar website. She submits the same proposal she submitted to four other foundations that month, with the funder's name swapped into the opening paragraph. She hears nothing for five months, then receives a form rejection. She makes a note to try again next year.</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <p>❑ No research confirming fit before submission</p> <p>❑ Generic template — program officers recognize this immediately</p> <p>❑ No relationship — proposal arrives cold</p> <p>❑ Rejection produces no learning, no relationship, no forward momentum</p>                                                                                                             |
| <p><b>[RELATIONSHIP GROWTH ARC — SAMPLE]</b></p> <p><i>Year 1: \$12,000 — Exploratory award, 8% of program budget. On-time report. Outcomes exceeded by 6%.</i></p> <p><i>Year 2: \$25,000 — Renewed with expanded scope. Invited program officer to site visit. Sent mid-year update.</i></p> <p><i>Year 3: \$42,000 — Funder cited our outcomes report in their annual review as a model for grantees.</i></p> <p><i>Year 5: \$68,000 — Multi-year grant, funder introduced our ED to two peer foundations at their</i></p>                                                                                                                                | <p>→ Year 1 ask is modest (8% of budget) — low risk for funder</p> <p>→ Each cycle adds a relationship touchpoint: site visit, mid-year update</p> <p>→ Exceeding outcomes in year 1 earns credibility for a larger year 2 ask</p> <p>→ By year 5, funder is making introductions — compounding returns on a relationship investment</p>                                 |

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

convening.

☐ **Team:** As a group: map your current funder relationships on the relationship growth arc. Which funders are you in year 1 with? Year 3+? Where are you treating a relationship as transactional that should be receiving more cultivation investment?

## Section 3 — Before & After Comparisons

Study each pair. The weak version shows what most organizations do. The strong version shows what sustains a grant program year after year.

### Comparison 1 — Needs Statement (Boilerplate Update)

#### ☐ **Weak**

*According to a 2019 report from the National Center for Children in Poverty, 1 in 5 children in the United States lives below the federal poverty line. In our community, economic hardship continues to affect families who struggle to access basic resources.*

#### ☐ **Strong**

*According to the most recent Community Needs Assessment published by [County] Health Department (2024), 31% of households in our service area reported food insecurity in the past 12 months — up from 24% in 2021. This 29% increase reflects the ongoing economic displacement following pandemic-era job losses, which have hit hardest among families earning below 200% of the federal poverty line.*

☐ **What makes the strong version more credible and more urgent? What specific update did the writer need to make before resubmitting?**

☐ **Team discussion:** Pull out your most recent grant proposal. What is the oldest data point in your needs statement? What would it take to replace it with something from the past 12 months? Assign someone to find that data before your next submission.

### Comparison 2 — Signature Logistics

Module 11

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

## ☐ Weak

*Our executive director is traveling the week before the deadline, but we are confident we will be able to get the proposal submitted on time. We have submitted many proposals before and always figure it out.*

## ☐ Strong

*Our submission timeline builds in signature logistics from the start. Board Chair signature is requested three weeks before the deadline and confirmed by calendar hold. Executive Director signature is obtained two weeks before the deadline. All authorized signatories are briefed on the submission date at the start of each grant cycle. Signature delays have not caused a missed deadline in three years.*

☐ What does the strong version demonstrate about organizational maturity that the weak version cannot? What would a funder infer about internal processes from each?

---

☐ **Team discussion:** Does your organization have a signature protocol? Identify who needs to sign every proposal you submit and confirm whether they have approved a standard lead-time for signature requests. Build it into your submission checklist.

## Comparison 3 — Funder Relationship Strategy

### ☐ Weak

*We plan to apply to several new foundations this year to diversify our funding base. We will research foundations online and submit proposals to those that seem like a good fit.*

### ☐ Strong

*Our FY2025 funder development strategy targets four new prospects identified through 990 research and peer referrals. For each, we have mapped a 12-month cultivation sequence: introduction at their Q1 briefing, a program update in Q2, a pre-application conversation request in Q3, and a tailored submission in Q4. We will track relationship status monthly and adjust based on program officer feedback.*

☐ What specific elements turn a vague funder diversification plan into a credible strategy? What would you need to know about each prospect before you could write a plan like this?

---

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

□ **Team discussion:** Map your organization's current new funder targets. For each one, write down: what research you have done, what relationship touchpoint has occurred, and what the next step is. If you cannot answer those three questions, the prospect is not yet being cultivated.

## Section 4 — Your Grant Strategy Builder

Complete each part below. By the end of this section you will have the foundation of a year-round grant development strategy that you can build on immediately.

### Part A — Your Funder Prospect List

Complete the table below for every funder you are actively cultivating or plan to cultivate in the next 12 months. Add rows as needed.

| Funder Name | Issue Area / Priority | Typical Grant Size | Deadline | Relationship Status | Next Action |
|-------------|-----------------------|--------------------|----------|---------------------|-------------|
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |
|             |                       |                    |          |                     |             |

□ **Tip:** Relationship Status options: No contact yet / Introduction made / Update sent / Pre-application conversation completed / Proposal submitted / Funded / Declined — in cultivation. Track this monthly.

□ **Team:** Review your prospect list as a group. Is every funder on this list a genuine alignment match — not just an available deadline? For each prospect, confirm: have you read their most recent 990 and grantee list? If not, assign someone to do that research before the next cycle.

### Part B — Your Annual Boilerplate Audit

Complete the audit table below before every major submission cycle. Identify what needs updating and who is responsible.

Module 11

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

| Proposal Section                 | What to Check                                                          | Status / Action Needed |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Needs Statement                  | <i>Most recent data: year &amp; source of oldest statistic?</i>        |                        |
| Accomplishments / Outcomes       | <i>Reflects most recently completed program year?</i>                  |                        |
| Evaluation Approach              | <i>Reflects current tools, systems, or external evaluator?</i>         |                        |
| Attachments                      | <i>Board list, financials, key staff, contributors — all current?</i>  |                        |
| Organizational History / Mission | <i>Reflects current programs, population, and leadership?</i>          |                        |
| Partner Descriptions             | <i>Reflects active, committed partners with current contributions?</i> |                        |

☐ **Your needs statement: What is the oldest data point currently in it? What is the source and year? What more current source could replace it?**

☐ **Your accomplishments section: Does it reflect the most recently completed program year? What are the two or three most specific, compelling outcomes you should be leading with?**

☐ **Team discussion:** Assign each boilerplate section to a team member for annual refresh. Set a calendar reminder 60 days before your first major deadline of each year. Boilerplate updates should never be a last-minute task.

## Part C — Your Grant Submission Checklist

Use the table below as your master submission checklist for every proposal. Adapt it to your organization's specific processes. Fill in the responsible person's name next to each task.

| Timeline | Task |
|----------|------|
|----------|------|

Module 11



# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

|                            |                                                                                   |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4–6 weeks before deadline  | Confirm funder priorities and review most recent 990 and grantee list             |
| 4–6 weeks before deadline  | Update needs statement data (replace any stats older than 2–3 years)              |
| 4–6 weeks before deadline  | Update accomplishments section with most recent program year data                 |
| 3–4 weeks before deadline  | Confirm all partner contributions and request letters of support                  |
| 3–4 weeks before deadline  | Update all attachments: board list, financials, key staff, contributors           |
| 2–3 weeks before deadline  | Complete first full draft of proposal narrative                                   |
| 2 weeks before deadline    | Identify who needs to sign and confirm their availability                         |
| 1 week before deadline     | Internal review: check narrative vs. budget alignment                             |
| 1 week before deadline     | Proofread for consistency: same population numbers, dates, and amounts throughout |
| 3–5 days before deadline   | Collect required signatures from Executive Director and Board Chair               |
| 1–2 days before deadline   | Final review of complete submission package including all attachments             |
| Day of submission          | Submit and document: save confirmation, record date, note notification timeline   |
| 3–6 months post-submission | Follow up professionally if no notification received by stated date               |
| Upon any decision          | Send thank-you regardless of outcome. Note relationship status for next cycle.    |

☐ **Tip:** Print this checklist and use it for every submission. A missed step that causes a deadline failure is almost always a step that had no assigned owner. Names matter.

☐ **Team:** Walk through this checklist as a group. Assign every task to a specific person or role. Confirm that your signature logistics allow at least two weeks for authorization. Build the full timeline backward from your next submission deadline.

## Part D — Your Ask Strategy

☐ **List your three most established funder relationships. For each, note your most recent grant amount and what a realistic next-cycle ask might be — and why.**

Module 11



# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

---

☐ List two to three new funders you are approaching for the first time this cycle. What percentage of their total program budget will your ask represent? Is it at or below 10%?

---

☐ Over the next three years, what does a realistic grant revenue growth trajectory look like for your organization? Name the funders you intend to deepen and the amounts you intend to grow toward.

---

☐ **Team discussion:** Review your ask strategy as a group. Are any of your current asks above 10% of the funder's typical grant range or your total program budget? How would you recalibrate? Assign someone to pull 990 data on each funder to confirm typical grant sizes.

## Section 5 — Final Self-Audit: Grant Program Readiness

---

This is your closing self-audit for the full Grant Writing Masterclass. Check every box that is honestly true for your organization right now. Use the unchecked boxes as your development roadmap going forward.

### Grant Campaign Strategy

- ☐ I treat grant development as an ongoing campaign — not a series of deadline reactions.
- ☐ I have an active, updated prospect list with at least five funders in active research or cultivation.
- ☐ For every prospect I plan to submit to, I have read their 990 and most recent grantee list.

Module 11

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

- I have at least one funder relationship where I send updates between proposal cycles.
- I budget 12 to 18 months of lead time when beginning to cultivate a new foundation prospect.

## Boilerplate Discipline

- I review and update my needs statement data before every major submission cycle.
- My accomplishments section reflects the most recently completed program year — not prior years or averages.
- I note any evolution in my evaluation approach in each new submission.
- I audit all eight attachment categories before every submission. Nothing is more than one year out of date.

## Submission Discipline

- I budget three to six months between submission and notification in all program planning.
- I have a signature logistics plan that ensures authorized signatures with at least two weeks of lead time.
- My grant requests with new funders are at or below 10% of my total program budget.
- I grow my asks incrementally as funder relationships deepen and my track record grows.

## Proposal Quality

- Every proposal I submit feels written specifically for that funder — not like a template with a name swapped in.
- My narrative and budget are consistent: same populations, same activities, same dollar amounts throughout.
- My proposals pass the coherence test: the summarizing sentence, needs statement, goals, activities, evaluation, and attachments all tell the same story.

## Organizational Readiness

- My attachments file is complete, current, and organized. I could assemble a full submission package within 24 hours.
- I track volunteer hours and in-kind contributions monthly and can generate a dollar value at any time.
- I have a sustainability plan that names specific funders, government relationships in progress, and earned revenue strategies.

# THE BUCK \$TARTS HERE

- My evaluation section describes expected results, measurement tools, and four dissemination channels — not just funder reporting.

---

**My three most important commitments coming out of this course:**

---

**The first action I will take this week:**

---

□ **Team:** Share your three commitments and your first action as a group. Pair up with an accountability partner from your cohort. Exchange contact information and commit to a check-in 30 days from now.

---

*“The skills you have built in this course  
are tools in service of something larger.  
The proposals you write will fund programs that change people’s lives.  
None of this happens overnight.  
All of it is worth building.  
You have what you need to begin.”*

— Grant Writing Masterclass, Module 11